FTSE 100 vs FTSE 250 — head-to-head

	FTSE 100	FTSE 250
Can ML pick winners better than 1/N (gross)?	Only weakly	Yes — clearer
Cheap to trade?	Relatively yes	No — wider spreads, thinner volume
Academic winner	1 MVO – 9.9% Trad 2 Ensemble – 9.7% ML 3 XGB – 9.6% ML	1 Ensemble – 13.3% ML 2 XGB – 12.1% ML 3 BL – 10.8% Trad
After realistic costs	1 1/N – 8.0% Trad 2 plain BL – 7.1% Trad 3 MVO – 6.8% Trad	1 plain BL – 8.3% Trad 2 1/N – 7.4% Trad 3 MVO – 3.9% Trad
Volatility forecast with academic cost	1 ML-BL – 18.7% ML 2 Min-Var / MVO – 12.8% Trad	1 ML-BL – 16.4% ML 2 Ensemble – 14.7% ML 3 XGB / MVO – 13.8% ML/Trad
Volatility forecast with realistic costs	1 Min-Var – 8.8% Trad 2 MVO – 7.7% Trad 3 1/N – 7.1% Trad	1 BL – 6.3% Trad 2 1/N – 6.3% Trad 3 MVO – 4.7% Trad

Trad ML ML/Trad = method type